

How Simple Ideas Become Billion Dollar Businesses (you can too)

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Executive Summary

Greg documents a packed day of founder meetings in NYC — with the creators of Cuts, Oakberry, and Santa Cruz Paleo — extracting repeatable lessons on simplicity, influencer marketing funnels, brand-first thinking, and why starting small beats waiting for the perfect idea.

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Morning Mindset: Pushing Comfort Zones to Kill Anxiety 0:22

- Greg opens with a personal revelation: the previous day was the **first time in years** he completed a major pitch without taking a beta blocker (doctor-prescribed) for anxiety
 - He attributes the breakthrough entirely to consistent, deliberate discomfort — not medication
 - His logic: if you start your day running through Times Square at 3 a.m. in the rain while exhausted and overwhelmed, walking into a polished corporate headquarters in Minneapolis feels easy by comparison
- The video is filmed at **5:15 a.m.** running through Manhattan, reinforcing the practice he's preaching
- Motivational frame directed at viewers: private airport terminal in New York had **150–250 private jets** on the tarmac
 - "They're no better than us, fam. It's ours for the taking."
- Context: it is **September 11th, 2026** — Greg frames the remaining **3.5 months of the year** as a window to jump into the arena before 2027

Steven Belli (Cuts): From Kickstarter to \$100M Bootstrapped Apparel 1:57

- Steven Belli is the founder of **Cuts**, a bootstrapped apparel brand that has generated **over \$100 million in revenue**
- Origin story:
 - Launched a **Kickstarter at the end of 2016**
 - Did **\$40,000 in sales with no product** in the first month — purely pre-orders/validation
 - Took about **a year to produce** because the team didn't know what they were doing
 - Revenue trajectory in first three years: **\$40K → \$2M → \$10M**
- Background before Cuts:
 - Worked at a marketing agency ("Lambis agency") whose clients included Corory Jewelry and Dani water bottles
 - Got fired from that job — "it was a sign"
- **First million-dollar day:** Black Friday 2020, at his parents' house in his dad's home office with co-founders from his small hometown
 - Initially hoped to hit \$500K that day; crossed \$500K by **10:00 a.m.**
 - Final figure was roughly **\$13–14M** (implied by the "1314" reference)
- Key lesson — **more products isn't better if it's not focused:**
 - Around 2022–23, the core black t-shirt started to plateau, so they experimented with "cool drops"
 - Cool drops had a moment but lacked restock plans — LTV of those customers was terrible
 - Cuts is fundamentally a **high-LTV business**: within one year, **50% of customers come back** — that repeat purchase is the lifeblood of profit
 - "The more can't come at the detriment of what got you there."
- Meta advertising insight:
 - **80% of all Cuts meta ads** feature women speaking to women, encouraging them to buy for their boyfriends/partners
 - Around the holidays, girlfriends/wives are the primary purchase driver
- On leveraging your personal network at launch:
 - Steven heard about a friend's new business launch **6 weeks in** — only because the friend quietly posted about it without telling anyone directly
 - His advice: scroll through your contacts ("you probably have 1,000 people you've never spoken to"), text them all, call in every favor you're owed
 - "If they are annoyed by you, delete them from your contacts anyway."
 - "Too many people have too much pride. You just got to go through the cringe moments."

Bloom's Influencer Marketing Funnel: The Four-Tier Playbook 6:52

- Bloom's current scale context:

- **#2 selling energy drink on Amazon**
- **#3 selling energy drink in Target**
- Spends **less than 5% of marketing budget on Meta** — described as "unheard of" in 2026 brand building
- **90% of marketing spend** goes to influencer marketing (tens of millions of dollars per year)
- Revenue is a "very healthy 9-figure business" — explicitly described as "over half a million dollars" was likely a joke/redaction; the implication is a 9-figure annual revenue number they're no longer allowed to state publicly
- Beating Celsius in multiple channels (stated as "hypothetically")
- Core philosophy: **commit to one playbook and run it to the moon** — do not diversify across multiple brand strategies
 - Bloom's playbook has barely changed in **10 years**, only adapting to platform shifts
- The **four-tier influencer funnel** (from broadest awareness to most prescriptive):

Tier	Type	Description	Goal
1	Niche Creators / Product Placement	Product appears naturally in background of unrelated content (e.g., Bloom can on counter during a steak fajitas video)	Pure impressions / awareness
2	Gifting & Ambassadors	Creators integrate product into daily content organically with no scripted messaging	Authentic integration
3	Paid Influencer	Traditional paid partnerships — creators treated as business partners, compensated properly	Targeted reach with accountability
4	Organic Social (Owned Pages)	Bloom's own Instagram and TikTok pages	Long-term compounding acquisition

- **Tier 1 — Product Placement / Niche Creators:**
 - Early Bloom example: mukbang videos where someone orders the entire Taco Bell menu — Bloom Greens just sits on the countertop
 - No brand validity, but potentially **15 million people** see Bloom Greens for the first time
 - Flywheel: those same 10–15M viewers likely shop at Target/Walmart regularly → see the Bloom end cap in-store → recall seeing it online → pick up the bottle → convert
 - Viral example: a DJ mixing video that also included an Ariana Grande song → **Ariana Grande reposted it on her story** — Bloom reached her audience for free through a third-party creator
 - Key insight: influencer marketing at scale only works because of volume — "if you try 10 videos, all 10 might flop. If you try 1,000, one goes viral and changes your trajectory."
- **Tier 2 — Gifting & Ambassadors:**
 - No prescribed messaging — creators told: "incorporate Bloom meaningfully into whatever you're already doing"

- Rule: **the more prescriptive you are, the worse the brand looks**
- **Tier 3 — Paid Influencers:**
 - Treated as true business partners
 - Bloom communicates genuine excitement about the creator's content and wants to be part of their journey
- **Tier 4 — Organic Social (Owned Pages):**
 - Don't underestimate: Bloom's **own TikTok page was their top creator in TikTok Shop in August** — a "wild stat"
 - Compounds slowly but becomes a major acquisition pillar over time (Bloom is 10 years in before seeing this payoff)
 - Advice for early-stage organic social:
 - Identify where the **customer has a fear of missing out** on a product or experience
 - Ask: "Where will someone say, 'I wish I had that in my daily routine'?"
 - Reverse-engineer content around that FOMO moment
 - Example: Bloom's 2027 summer campaign theme is **"the summer you never forget"** — lake days, Miami trips, best-season vibes
 - Goal: become the brand someone reaches for on a Tuesday morning when they want to hit snooze — a vibe they can associate with

Brand-First vs. Revenue-First Thinking 12:44

- Question posed: how do early founders resist chasing quick sales in favor of brand building?
- Greg's answer: "I never cared about revenue. All I cared about was making a huge brand. I just want to build the biggest energy drink."
- "Chasing sales is the absolute most toxic thing."
 - Caveat: there are real moments when an invoice hits and you run a **25% off sale to make rent** — that's fine, just don't make it a habit
- Before the energy drink, Bloom bootstrapped **\$180 million** with a **bloat supplement product**
 - "Bloat" is described as the best word in the marketing rolodex
 - Before/after content (stomach before and after taking the product) is "the greatest thing in the marketing universe" — what took Bloom from **\$5M to \$75M**

Georgios Frangulas (Oakberry): Simplicity Scales 13:36

- Georgios Frangulas is the founder of **Oakberry**, a global açai brand doing **over \$300 million a year in revenue**
- Background:
 - Born and raised in Brazil, went to law school there
 - Moved to Miami in **2013–14** to pursue real estate

- Bought an apartment to flip, made money, moved back to Brazil for 6 months, then moved to California
- Had the Oakberry idea while **living in LA**
- The insight that sparked Oakberry:
 - In LA, people were lining up and paying **\$20 for shitty açai** — long waits, no standards
 - Açai originates from Brazil and **can only be sourced from the Amazon forest** — nowhere else
 - "This is not real açai. People are going for it. If I figure out a way to apply American F&B / QSR standards, it's going to make sense."
- Scale:
 - Opening **one new store every two days**
 - **Europe is the biggest market by far**
 - Switzerland locations do **over a million euros per location per month**
 - Heavily franchised model
- Competitive advantage — **fully vertical supply chain:**
 - Georgios owns the factory in Brazil and supplies all açai to his franchisees
 - Take rate is significantly higher than the typical franchise model (**3–6%**) because he controls the supply
- **Biggest takeaway (Greg's summary):** "Simplicity scales."
 - **95% of Oakberry's business is one product** — the açai bowl
 - Not trying to sell 20 types of sandwiches, lattes, and protein shakes
 - Because the menu is so simple, a **whole store can operate with 1–2 employees** most of the time

Simplicity scales. 95% of his business is one product. That's why he can have one to two employees per store.



Scouting NYC Satellite Offices 16:41

- Greg tours potential **Bloom East Coast / NYC satellite office** spaces in Soho and surroundings
- **Option 1 (favored):** Former WeWork space
 - **25-foot ceilings**
 - Communal rooftop workspace
 - Large conference room, 4 toilets, nice kitchen, storage room
 - Located in **center of Soho**
 - Negotiating price: approximately **\$80,000/month**
 - Greg's take: "You would be proud to have this in the background of content." He specifically verified unglamorous necessities (storage, toilets, kitchen)
- **Option 2 (passed):** East Village location
 - **\$35,000/month** — roughly half the price
 - Half the size, ground level with a garage door

- Greg's verdict: "Can't put lipstick on a pig."
- Staffing math driving the space decision:
 - Content team: ~5 people
 - Craig's digital marketing team: 3–5 people
 - Total with visiting creators: quickly reaches **25 people**
 - Greg's pattern: every time he's gotten a space sized for the current team, he's "an idiot in 6 months" when they've outgrown it — so he's deliberately sizing up

Jack's Dining Room: Media Empires and Monetizing Influence 18:56

- Meeting with Jack (Jack's Dining Room) — millions of followers across platforms, food content creator turned media and events company
- **Two business lines under "Yes Group"** (the business arm, started ~2 years ago):
 - **Reserve Experience:** Curated, invite-only dinners — Michelin star chefs, high-profile guests (Michael Rubin, Tom Graves, Joe Burrow, Leonardo DiCaprio mentioned)
 - Guests flown to locations like the Hamptons
 - **Food Festival: 10,000-person food festival** happening in two weeks from filming
- Started Jacktown **4+ years ago** as pure content; Yes Group monetizes that existing funnel
- Key observation: "Anyone can go viral today. If you can get 10 people to show up in a room, that's more impressive than 10 million views."
- Product idea discussion — Greg pressure-tests a new concept Jack's team is developing:
 - Greg suggests the easier, lower-risk path: make a **slightly better condiment** (ketchup, mustard, mayo) in the vein of Sir Kensington, Primal Kitchen, or Smash Kitchen — "a hit out of the park" given the audience
 - Jack's team pushback: Jack is an **eater, not a cooking creator** — a condiment doesn't integrate organically into his content format
 - Greg's counterpoint on their actual concept: "Don't say the word Birkin. That's not mass. You're going to sell a \$20 product and you need to sell millions of them every month. Always keep the real consumer in mind."
 - Practical benchmark: Bloom does **hundreds of millions through Walmart** — mass-market positioning is non-negotiable at scale
 - Framing: "Yes, Chef will get you off the ground and make you premium out of the gate. But how do you make sure this is actually a business that can do \$100 million?"
- Meta-observation on the creator economy in 2026:
 - "Currency in 2026 is more about your influence and status on social media than it is about money."
 - These media empire founders get access to **opportunities money can't buy** — flown to other countries for Michelin-star experiences, driven in Ferraris by chefs, etc.

Brendan Rue (Santa Cruz Paleo): Starting Small and Learning Fast 23:11

- Brendan Rue is founder of **Santa Cruz Paleo**, a health and supplement brand that has sold **over 417,000 products through TikTok Shop alone**
- Mission framing: "Make the world healthier" — but acknowledges "you can't save souls in an empty church," so revenue has to follow
- The brand funds his broader health content mission; without it, he'd have to take gambling or alcohol brand deals like other creators
- Currently targeting: **\$10M/month in e-commerce + retail**
- On the retail question (is it good or bad for a brand?):
 - Uses the **one-way door vs. two-way door** decision framework:
 - **One-way door**: Selling 25% of your company to private equity — very hard to reverse
 - **Two-way door**: Launching in Walmart — if it doesn't work, you can pull out and return to baseline
 - Takeaway: retail is a two-way door, so just try it and see for yourself
- Also introduced: **Goldie** — a new brand making **manuka honey lemonade**, heading into Whole Foods
- Bloom's geographic concentration strategy (relevant sidebar):
 - Bloom has **14% market share on energy drinks in New York City** — far above their national average
 - Strategy: **over-index resources in New York** because influential people who discover products there spread them nationally and globally
 - "Win New York, you can win anywhere."
- **Advice for aspiring founders**:
 - Start with something smaller than your moonshot
 - Even if only 10 people in your town would buy it, there are **10 people in every town across America** who would — that's a real market
 - Try to sell **500 units first** — you don't actually know what works until you have real customer feedback
 - Do more of what people like, less of what they don't
 - Get the fundamentals in place: **Shopify store, email list** — get the flywheel going
 - As you learn from consumers and understand how business works, your real moonshot idea will emerge organically

The Real Game: Pursuit Over Dopamine 25:48

- Greg's closing philosophy on why building a business beats passive entertainment:
 - Compares entrepreneurship to **GTA 6 in real life** — the game is real and the stakes are real
 - "Once you leave the status quo system and start to really play the game that is a life of pursuit... you will find a whole new level of fulfillment that is greater than any type of quick dopamine that gambling or GTA 6 does."
 - Applies to any pursuit — building a business, becoming the best mountain biker, anything hard
 - "The real answer to male depression is get in shape and go find something hard to go do."

- Long-term frame: "All I want is to be able to look back and say I [__] tried."
- Closing reassurance for hesitant founders — echoing the two-way door concept:
 - "You can launch a business, [__] up, and go get your job back."
 - The downside is reversible; the regret of not trying is not